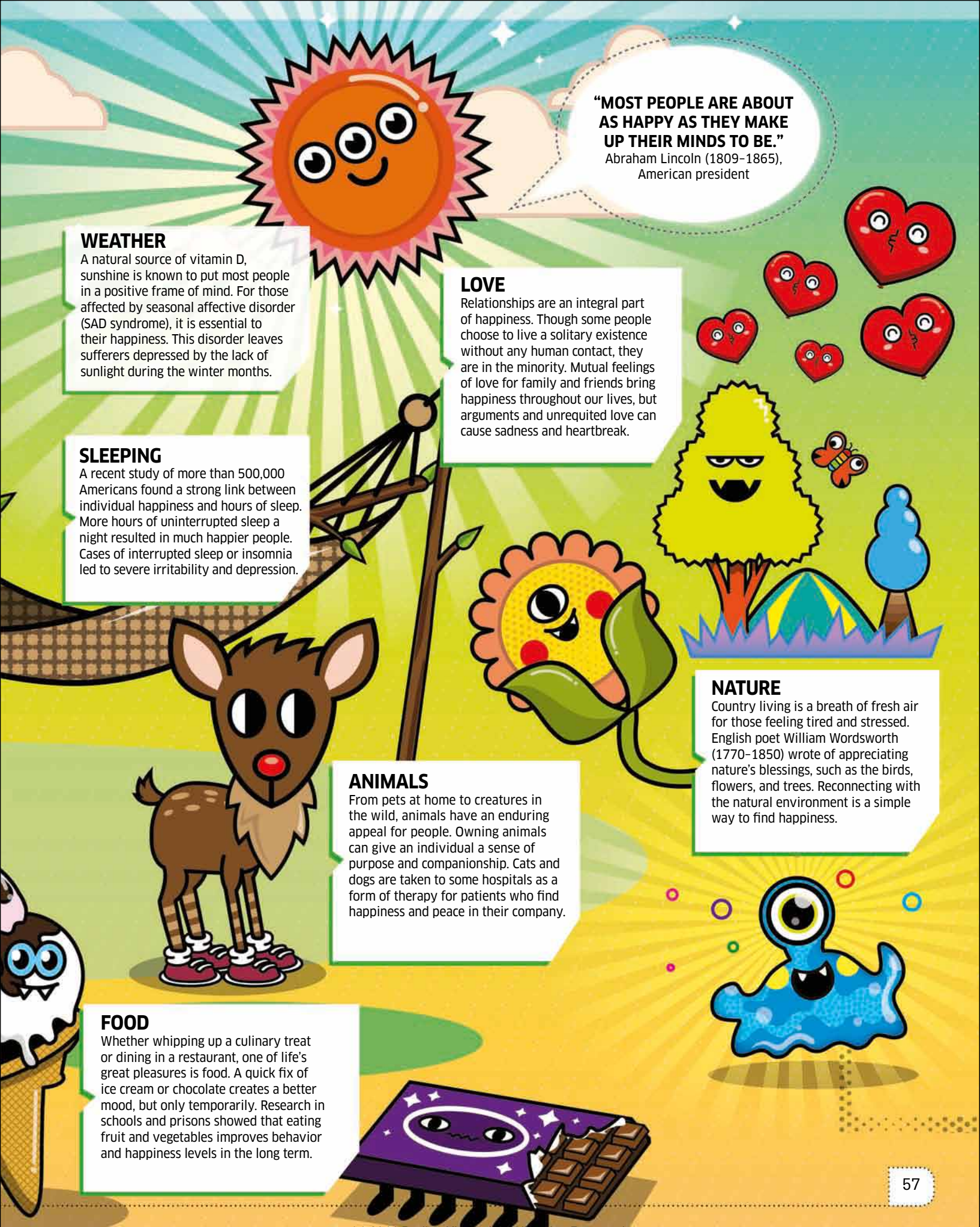




"MOST PEOPLE ARE ABOUT AS HAPPY AS THEY MAKE UP THEIR MINDS TO BE."

Abraham Lincoln (1809-1865),
American president

WEATHER

A natural source of vitamin D, sunshine is known to put most people in a positive frame of mind. For those affected by seasonal affective disorder (SAD syndrome), it is essential to their happiness. This disorder leaves sufferers depressed by the lack of sunlight during the winter months.

SLEEPING

A recent study of more than 500,000 Americans found a strong link between individual happiness and hours of sleep. More hours of uninterrupted sleep a night resulted in much happier people. Cases of interrupted sleep or insomnia led to severe irritability and depression.

LOVE

Relationships are an integral part of happiness. Though some people choose to live a solitary existence without any human contact, they are in the minority. Mutual feelings of love for family and friends bring happiness throughout our lives, but arguments and unrequited love can cause sadness and heartbreak.

ANIMALS

From pets at home to creatures in the wild, animals have an enduring appeal for people. Owning animals can give an individual a sense of purpose and companionship. Cats and dogs are taken to some hospitals as a form of therapy for patients who find happiness and peace in their company.

NATURE

Country living is a breath of fresh air for those feeling tired and stressed. English poet William Wordsworth (1770-1850) wrote of appreciating nature's blessings, such as the birds, flowers, and trees. Reconnecting with the natural environment is a simple way to find happiness.

FOOD

Whether whipping up a culinary treat or dining in a restaurant, one of life's great pleasures is food. A quick fix of ice cream or chocolate creates a better mood, but only temporarily. Research in schools and prisons showed that eating fruit and vegetables improves behavior and happiness levels in the long term.